

## TOURING PLAYERS IN THE EARLY YEARS OF ELIZABETH: WHAT WERE THEY PLAYING?

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During the first decade of the reign of Queen Elizabeth, 1558–1568, William Cecil, the Queen's First Minister, re-activated the policy first begun by Thomas Cromwell in 1535 to use plays and players as tools of state propaganda. As early as 1968, David Bevington noted this in *Tudor Drama and Policy*, citing a letter of the Spanish Ambassador, Gomez Suarez de Figueroa, count of Feria, to his master, Philip II of Spain.<sup>1</sup> The idea was picked up by Paul White in *Theatre and Reformation*,<sup>2</sup> but neither scholar was able to take the idea much beyond the simple fact that it was so. Recently I have been looking at this idea from the double perspective of a consideration of Cecil himself and a gathering together of the information that has been collected by Records of Early English Drama about the touring companies that emerged in the mid sixteenth century and their patrons.<sup>3</sup> Everything we know about Cecil's education, circles of friendship and marriage, and intellectual and religious affinity makes it plausible that he would support the use of drama as a means to strengthen Elizabeth's hold on power and solidify the Protestant cause. From his university days he had been accustomed to seeing plays that were powerful Protestant polemics. He was a close associate of Richard Morison who had enunciated the theory that vernacular plays should be used for the inculcating of Protestant principles in the general population that had strongly influenced Thomas Cromwell.<sup>4</sup> During the time Cecil was part of the inner circle of government in the Edwardian years and again when he became Elizabeth's first minister in 1558, the pattern of provincial touring by players patronized either by the monarch or by members of the Privy Council, begun under Cromwell's ascendancy (1535–1541), was reinstated. A careful study of the patterns of patronage based on REED's *Patrons and Performances* website<sup>5</sup> provides a picture of the playing companies that were on the road in mid century and the names of their patrons. From this information it is possible to come to a sense of how many companies were patronized by members of the Privy Council or people closely associated with them. In Cromwell's time the percentage recorded of such companies was 83%; under Edward 77% and in the first five years of Elizabeth's reign 83%. Of the 173 performances so far recorded in those years (1558–1563),

99 or more than half are by three companies — 44 were by the queen's company, 35 the company of Lord Robert Dudley (not yet the Earl of Leicester) and 20 the company of his brother Ambrose the Earl of Warwick. Between 1563 and 1568 the number of companies increases and, although the companies of the counsellors are still 'on the road', the percentage of companies patronised by them diminishes.<sup>6</sup> This paper, that seeks to suggest their repertoire, is a next step in the exploration of the nature of early Elizabethan drama.

Much of the rhetoric of the Henrician and Edwardian plays was anti-papal. Plays such as *Pammachius*,<sup>7</sup> performed in Latin in Cambridge in 1545 rocked the academic and religious world,<sup>8</sup> while 'on the ground' John Bale's strident condemnation of the Roman hierarchy left no doubt where he stood in the controversy. The continuing attacks on the papacy from the stage during John Dudley Earl of Warwick's years of power as the Lord Protector of Edward VI are mentioned by the Venetian ambassador writing home in May 1551 as he speaks of 'the disobedience of the English to the Pope ... their demonstrations of contempt for him, in paintings, comedies, and in all their amusements ...'<sup>9</sup> A month earlier, Warwick, in Edward's name, had issued the following proclamation stating clearly that it was the duty of the sovereign to ensure the setting 'furth of Goddes holy worde and thestablishment of a pure and sincere religion, conformable to goddes institucion, and the vsage of the holy catholique churche'.<sup>10</sup> It lamented the effect that idle invention in books and plays are having on the 'kinges maiesties louyng and faithful subiectes' and forbad the printing and playing of such things.<sup>11</sup> Early theatre historians tended not to read beyond the prohibitions ignoring the crucially important exception that followed:

onles the same be firste allowed by his maiestie, or his priuie counsayl in writing signed with his maiesties most gracious hand or the handes of sixe of his sayd priuie counsayl, vpon payne of Imprisonment without bayle or mayne price, and further fine at his maiesties pleasor. Nor that any common players or other persons, vpon like paines, to play in thenglish tong, any maner of Enterlude, play or mattré, without they haue special licence to shew for the same in writing vnder his maiesties signe or signed by .vi. of his highness priuie counsaill: willing and straightly charging and commaunding al Justices, Mayors, Shirifes, Bailifes, Constables, & other officers and ministers, diligently to enquire for, and serche out al maner offenders within the limites and compasse of their

commissions, and specially al suche as shal offende against any  
poinctes or braunches expressly set further in this proclamation,  
and to punishe the same without remission ...<sup>12</sup>

If permission was granted by the King or six members of the Privy Council and a license obtained, such plays could be performed. Local authorities were to ensure that any players seeking to perform within their jurisdictions had the requisite license. Eight years later, on 16 May 1559, Elizabeth issued her 'proclamation against plays' requiring the licensing of plays but also requiring that no plays be played 'wherin either matters of religion or of the governance of the estate of the common weale shall be handled or treated'. This has frequently been taken as a prohibition against using drama as either political or religious propaganda. But again there is a qualifying clause that follows the apparent blanket prohibition 'beyng no meete matters be wrytten or treated vpon, but by menne of auctoritie, learning, and wisdom, nor to be handled before any audience but of graue and discreete persons'.<sup>13</sup> Like its Edwardian predecessor, this one proclamation can be seen as directed at unauthorised plays and playing, not at plays sanctioned by the 'menne of auctoritie, learning and wisdom' who constituted the Privy Council and their agents in the counties, cities and towns of England.

The evidence being gathered by REED about the travelling companies comes, almost entirely in the mid sixteenth century, from official town records. When a company sought the permission of the local authorities to perform in their jurisdiction, the town councils, acting on the repeated injunctions from the crown to fulfil their role as censor, commanded a performance and paid. The surviving civic financial records, therefore, provide the evidence for *authorised* performances. Companies not patronised by the gentry or nobility rarely appear in the civic records of the mid sixteenth century. The payments to players (as opposed to musicians) from neighbouring towns and parishes so frequently found in the records up to the mid 1530s have virtually disappeared, especially from the records of the South and East. The proclamations against 'rogues and vagabonds' and 'common players' in this period are not against these patronised companies but the unauthorised, uncensored entertainers whose nature and repertoire we have no way of knowing and whose presence is rarely found in surviving records.

But what was the repertoire of these 'patronised' companies? Three scholars — David Bevington in both *Mankind to Marlowe* and *Tudor Drama and Politics*,<sup>14</sup> Tom Craik in *The Tudor Interlude*,<sup>15</sup> and, more recently, Paul

White in *Theatre and Reformation*<sup>16</sup> — have studied the plays of the mid sixteenth century. Bevington in *Mankind to Marlowe* and Craik in *The Tudor Interlude* focus on the structure and staging of the plays, while Paul White in *Theatre and Reformation* and Bevington in *Tudor Drama and Politics* tackle where the plays fit into the cultural and religious landscape of the Tudor period. Only White has any sense that some of these plays may have been part of the touring repertoire of ‘provincial’ companies. This was a bold new suggestion in 1993 but, as the REED evidence has been building up, it seems indeed to be correct.

When I set out to consider the many plays listed in Harbage and Schoenbaum’s *Annals of English Drama*<sup>17</sup> that could have been available to the companies before 1568, it was obvious that that not all of them would be suitable for a touring repertoire. The auspices of many are also known — school plays or plays commissioned by the court, for example. I eventually winnowed my list down to those plays whose auspices are listed by Harbage and Schoenbaum as ‘unknown’ or ‘offered for acting’ and those whose doubling patterns make them suitable for small touring companies. My choice was further sharpened by Paul White’s exhaustive list<sup>18</sup> and, occasionally, his sense of the time ‘limits’ (as *Annals* puts it) that an earlier play could have been available to the acting troupes. Some obviously Edwardian plays have been provided with epilogues that name Queen Elizabeth and have been included in this analysis. The group I have selected is, of course, dependent upon the survival of the texts. Any and all generalisations about the nature of drama must be understood within the context of a performance rather than a print tradition. There are many things that we cannot know, but starting from the double premise that playing companies were patronised by leading members of Elizabeth’s government and that the plays were known to have been propaganda pieces, it is possible to analyse these plays and attempt to draw some conclusions.

Many of these plays do not have modern editions. Some are available only in black-letter facsimiles through the Malone Society reprints, or through John S. Farmer’s early twentieth-century *Tudor Facsimile Texts* (several with the speech headings cropped), which have been made more generally available online through the Internet archive Early English Books Online<sup>19</sup> or through Literature Online.<sup>20</sup> I began my consideration by looking carefully at the epilogues. I knew many had prayers for the Queen but what I hadn’t realised is that almost universally they include prayers for the Council and many also include prayers for the local authorities.

William Wager's *The Longer Thou Livest*<sup>21</sup> ends with these stanzas spoken by the three Virtues Exercitation, Pietie, and Discipline:

*Exercitation.*

God saue the Queenes Highnes, and the Nobilitie,  
Defend her long we beseeche thee, Lorde:  
Which is the Patronesse of all humilitie,  
A setter forth of truth, and loue of concord.

*Pietie.*

God preserue the Queenes most honorable Councell,  
With all the Magistrates of this Region,  
That they may agree to maintaine Gods Gospell,  
Which is the most true and sincere Religion,  
To roote out Antechrist I pray God they may take payne  
Then will the Lord send them honour and fame,  
And after this life, geue them the reward of the same.

*Discipline*

Pray wee for the Clergie and hole Spiritualitie,  
That they may teach and set forth Gods truth always,  
I beseeche you, let vs pray for the hole communaltie,  
That vpon us all, God mercy take may,  
So that eche one of vs, in the right way may staye,  
All glory, honour, impery, maiestie, and dignitie,  
Be geuen both now & euermore to the blessed Trinitie.

(1971–88)

The epilogue to the enigmatic *Pedlers' Prophecy* (not printed until 1595 but dated by both Harbage and Schoenbaum and White as early Elizabeth)<sup>22</sup> includes an opportunity for the patron to be named. Again it is the Virtues who speak the lines:

*Judgment*

First let vs pray for the Queens Maiesty on this part,  
Almightie God prosper and defend her Royall Maiestie,  
Amen say all those, that haue a true English heart,  
We haue all cause to pray for her Graces prosperitie.

*Justice*

Also her honorable Councell God prosper & saue,  
And that honorable T. N. &c of N. chiefly:  
Whom as our good Lord and maister, found we haue,  
Good Lord we beseech thee, to be his guide daily

1458–65

As has so often happened, as REED evidence has shed light on an unexpected aspect of theatre history, apparently formulaic passages passed over by earlier scholars take on new significance. I do not believe that it is an accident that the epilogues to these plays are so inclusive. They show us that the playing companies were well aware of whom they were ultimately serving with their performances (the Crown) and who were the essential local officials and patrons to include in their concluding lines.

One of the most interesting plays in the group is *New Custom*.<sup>23</sup> Although it was not printed until 1573 and 'limited' by Harbage and Schoenbaum to 1570–1573, Paul White suggests its dates can be extended back to 1564.<sup>24</sup> It is certainly the most blatant of all the plays in its attack on the Marian church and its championing of the virtues of the Elizabethan settlement. The characters (that can be played by four actors) are two Catholic priests (Perverse Doctrine and Ignorance); two Protestant Ministers (New Custom and Light of the Gospel); three Virtues (Edification, Assurance, and Gods Felicity) and three Vices (Hypocrisy, Crueltie, and Avarice). Towards the end of the second act (of three), Crueltie and Avarice revel in their activities during their ascendancy under Mary:

But Heresie, fie on that, that is the greatest of all.  
 Euery stockes should be full, euery prison and iayle.  
 Some would I beate with roddes, some scorge at a cartes tayle.  
 Some hoyse their heeles vpwarde, some beate in a sacke,  
 Some manickle their fingers, some binde in the racke.  
 Some would I sterue for hunger, some would I hange priuilie,  
 Saying that them selues so dyed desperately.  
 Some would I accuse of matters of great weight,  
 Openly to hange them as trespassours streight.  
 A thousand mo waies could I tell, and not misse,  
 Which here in England I may say to you I haue practised ere this,  
 And trust by his woundes, Auarice, some agayne for to trie  
 How so euer the world goe before that I die. Ciiij<sup>r-v</sup>

And he goes on to describe his delight as the 'heretics' were 'howling together in the fier' comparing their noise to the 'crie of houndes folowing the Hare. | Or a rablement of Bandogges barking at a Beare' (Ciiij<sup>v</sup>). Avarice then tells the story of a trick 'In England which my selfe plaied in the daies of queene Marie' when he betrayed his brother to the Marian authorities in order to gain the brother's inheritance (Ciiij<sup>v-iv<sup>r</sup></sup>). The two

priests, Perverse Doctrine and Ignorance, then seek the help of Cruelty and Avarice to deal with the 'Heresie came lately in place, | And Newe custome that vile Scismatique' (Civ<sup>I</sup>), and whom they had earlier identified with Geneva. Perverse Doctrine remarks at the end of Act 2 Scene 2, 'For since these Geneuian doctours came so faste into this lande / Since that time it was neuer merie with Englande' (Ciiij<sup>I</sup>).

New Custom, on the other hand, claims not to be new. In an argument with Perverse Doctrine in Act 1 Scene 2 he claims to be the Primitive Church and so older than Catholicism. It is Catholicism that has introduces new custom to the church:

New fashions you haue constitute in Religion, agayne  
Abuse of the Sacraments then hath ben tofore,  
Haue you brought, and in nombre haue you made them more,  
Then Christ euer made: Wherefore shew your auctoritie:  
Or els haue you done to the Church great iniurie.  
Thappostles neuer taught your transubstantiation  
Of bread into fleshe, or any [s]uch fashion. B iij<sup>I</sup>

In the third act, Light of the Gospel intervenes in the dispute between Perverse Doctrine and New Custom. They exchange insults, Light of the Gospel calling Perverse Doctrine 'impe of Antechrist and seede of the deuyll, | Borne to all wickednesse, and misled in all euyl' while Perverse Doctrine calls him 'stinking Heretike' (D ij<sup>I</sup>). Surprisingly, especially after Light of the Gospel has defended the Calvinist Doctrine of the Elect (D ii<sup>V</sup>), Perverse Doctrine sees the error of his ways after listening to Light of the Gospel preach, and converts, becoming 'Sincere doctrine', while New Custom's name is changed to 'primitiue Constitution' (D iij<sup>I-V</sup>). The play ends after a prayer by Edification for the defence of the church in England and abroad with a prayer for the queen and counsel spoken by Assurance,

Preserue our noble Queene Elizabeth, and her counsell all,  
With thy heauenly grace, sent from thy seate supernall.  
Graunt her, and them longe to lyue, her to raigne, them to see,  
What may alwaies be best for the weale publiques commoditie.  
(Div<sup>V</sup>)

There is a good deal of discussion in the disputes among the clergy about the details of the way the church was ordered and functioned before and after the Reformation. Some of it concerns vestments — a hot topic in

the 1560s. Paul White argues that the play was originally about the vestiary controversy and altered to down play that element before it was printed in 1573.<sup>25</sup> Although that controversy is clearly part of the context of this play, there is much more here that is foundational to the religious and political turmoil of the mid-century, particularly to the experience of the English during Mary's reign. The message of the play is that if Perverse Doctrine can be converted, then it is possible that under the new queen religious harmony can be achieved.

A similar pattern of redemption is followed by the Edwardian play *Lusty Iuuentus* that was printed in 1550, and reprinted, (twice, by two different printers) in 1565.<sup>26</sup> In the second edition, the original epilogue aimed at Edward is adapted for Elizabeth, with *king* changed to *queen*, and the personal pronouns adjusted:

*Good counsel*

Now let vs make our supplications together  
 For y<sup>e</sup> prosperous estate of oure noble & vertuous quene,  
 That in her godly procedinges she may still perseuer,  
 Which seketh the glory of God a boue all other thyng.  
 O Lord endue her hart with true vnderstandyng.  
 And geue her a prosperous lyfe, longe ouer vs to rayne,  
 To gouerne & rule her people as a worthy seruant.

*Iuuentus*

Also, let vs for all the nobilite of this realme,  
 And namely for those, whome her grace auctorised  
 To mayntayne the publike welth ouer vs & them,  
 That they may se his gracyous actes published,  
 And they, beyng truly admonished,  
 By the complaynt of them, which are wrongfulli opprest  
 May se[k]le a reformation, and se it redrest. [text: sesse]

*Good counsell*

Then shall thys land enioy great quietnes & rest  
 And geue vnto God most herty thanks therfore,  
 To whome be honor, prase and glory for euermore 1115–31

*Lusty Iuuentus* — essentially an educational morality about the way to raise a child — follows the classic religious morality pattern of the arrival at a state of grace, the fall from grace, followed by repentance and a return to a state of grace. The radical difference from traditional Catholic moralities



is that the Vices (particularly Hypocrisy) represent Catholicism. Both the first and second conversions depend on the words of scripture not the sacraments — the Word is predominant. The act of preaching plays a major role in the play. Lusty is tempted and falls on his way to a ‘preaching’ and then is converted by a sermon. This is in keeping with the policy of the Elizabethan church to establish civic preachers supported by the municipal authorities all over England. *Lusty Iuventus* is a lively play full of songs and lively chat from the Vices but, as David Bevington remarks, ‘Even in its amusing scenes the play is offering serious morality to a widespread audience’.<sup>27</sup>

Another revival, this time possibly from the Marian period, is *Wealth and Health*.<sup>28</sup> Bevington believes this to be a popular rather than a court play.<sup>29</sup> For all its classic morality form, the play is not overtly religious, with the essential choices being a matter of judgment rather than doctrine. Wealth, Health, and Liberty are corrupted by seeming virtues Wit and Will who turn out to be the Shrewd Wit and Ill Will. Remedy rescues the heroes in the end. The Vices are full of energy and the play contains the first of many sustained satires, in these plays, of Flemish merchants. Remedy ends the play with

Jesu preserue quene Elizabeth y<sup>t</sup> noble princis worthy  
 Jesu continue her helth long for to endure  
 Jesu indue her w<sup>[t]</sup> vertue grace & honour  
 Jesu maintaine the lords of y<sup>e</sup> counsel to execute good remedi euer  
 Jesu spede and helpe al them gods honour to further  
 Jesu increase the comunaltie to prosper and doo wel. 959–64

*New Custom*, *Lusty Iuventus*, and *Wealth and Health* all end ‘happily’ in that the central figure is restored at the end. A second group of plays that Bevington discusses in his chapter ‘Dual Protagonists and a Formula for Homiletic Tragedy’<sup>30</sup> do not end well for the central character. In the period we are considering, these plays include William Wager’s *Enough is as Good as a Feast*, *The Longer Thou Livest the More Fool Thou Art*, and *The Trial of Treasure*;<sup>31</sup> Ulpian Fulwell’s *Like will to Like*;<sup>32</sup> and Thomas Lupton’s *All for Money*.<sup>33</sup> Wager and Fulwell were clergymen and although there is no evidence about Lupton except from his writings as a political and religious controversialist he certainly had theological training. White refers to four of these five plays as ‘money plays’ since the central concern is the prudent way to handle money.<sup>34</sup> Bevington has shown how these plays no longer have a central figure in the old morality pattern whose soul

or judgment is being fought over. Rather there are two 'alternate camps of godly and profane figures' with the plays being structured around 'a series of contrasts between those who are unquestionably saved and those who are irreparably damned'.<sup>35</sup> In this way, these plays incorporate into their structure the familiar 'debate' or 'dialogue' format of the court interludes of John Heywood.

Two of the Wager plays end with the central figure (Moros in *The Longer Thou Livest*, and Worldly Man in *Enough is as Good as a Feast*) being carried off to Hell on the Devil's back while in the third, *Trial of Treasure*, Lust is converted into dust. All have the threads of tragedy in them, as the title of Bevington's chapter suggests. *The Longer Thou Livest* begins as a conventional educational morality with standard comic turns as the child resists his school masters. But as Moros ages, his sins become more vicious, he refuses to heed good counsel, and is finally struck down by God's Judgment. Even as he is dying, he refuses to mend his ways. In *Enough*, Worldly Man does repent for a time but is tempted by wealth, cheats at business, and extorts money from all his dependents. When he is struck down by God's Plague, his companion Vices, Ignorance and Covetous, cannot help him, and he dies a lingering death on stage. *Trial of Treasure* follows a similar pattern with a debate between Lust and Just that ends with Lust going over to Treasure. This play is much more physical than *Enough* and *The Longer Thou Livest* (perhaps the reason why some question its ascription to Wager). There are wrestling matches and, at one point, Just puts a physical bridle on Inclination. However, it ends in a familiar Wager pattern with, this time, God's Visitation (aided by Time) striking down Lust. Wager's doctrinal position is made very clear in *The Longer Thou Livest* when he gives the following speech to the Vice Ignorance:

Ignorance yea Ignorance is my name,  
 A meete mate with fooles to dwell,  
 A qualitie of an auncient fame,  
 And yet drowne I many one in hell,  
 The Papistes which the truth do know,  
 Lord how I haue nuseled<sup>36</sup> them in my science.  
 I have so taught them, that how so euer the wind blow,  
 They shall still encline to my sentence,  
 So that though they haue knowledge and cunning,  
 They are but Ignoraunt and fooles,  
 After euery Heresie and Poperie, they are running,

And delight daily to learne at newe scholes.  
Also many that do them selues abuse,  
Some in that Iniquitie and some in this,  
By *Ignorance* they do them selues excuse,  
As though they know not that they did amisse,  
When theyr conscience beare them record,  
That theyr actes are wicked and euill,  
Therefore, when they shall come before the Lord,  
He shall condemne them with Satan the Deuill. 1273-92

Everything Wager writes was informed by his strong Protestant views even when they are not overt or when he uses them for comic effect as, when Covetous in *Enough* cannot save Worldly Man, he cries, 'Saint Uncumber be with us, and the blessed Saint Anthony | Help, help, our Lady of Walsingham and all her holy company' (1331-2).

The other plays in this group have similar patterns. Nicholas Newfangle, the lively Vice in Fulwell's *Like will to Like*, is associated with the devil from the first and eventually is carried off by the Devil as the Virtues triumph in the end. Again the good characters and bad characters alternate scenes. Bevington points out that the moral of this play is that sober effort will produce tangible rewards<sup>37</sup> and quotes the play:

For vertue and fortune be not at strife.  
Where vertue is, fortune must needs grow;  
But fortune without vertue hath soon the overthrow. D ij

With the heavy emphasis on 'punishment and destruction for a misspent life' and 'no mankind hero to reclaim virtue', Bevington concludes that the tone of this play is 'predominantly satiric and denunciatory rather than morally positive'.<sup>38</sup>

Finally in this group, *All for Money* is structured with the same alternating scenes between the good and bad characters and, like the other plays, is primarily concerned with greed 'stresses the dark side of human nature'.<sup>39</sup> This play is less stridently Protestant, but the treatment of the theme of *radix malorum est cupiditas* is grounded in the Protestant ethic with the damnation of the covetous in the New Testament figures of Judas and Dives and the triumph of the Virtues, Admonition, Virtue, Humility, and Charity.

While he was Regius Professor of Divinity at Cambridge (1549-1551), Martin Bucer, the continental Reformer, suggested that the Bible was a natural source for plots that were both exciting and inspiring. He wrote in

his *De Honestis Ludis* (1551) that scripture is ‘thickly packed with godlike and heroic people, with emotion, with character, with actions and with unforeseen events’ with the ‘wonderful power to strengthen faith in God, to arouse love and desire of God and to create and increase not only admiration of piety and justice, but also the horror of impiety and of the sowing and fostering of every kind of evil’.<sup>40</sup> Several plays being performed in this period followed his suggestion. The Edwardian *Vertuous and Godlye Susanna*,<sup>41</sup> with its portrayal of middle-class piety, was not published until 1578, *The Godly Queene Hester*,<sup>42</sup> an even earlier play, was not published until 1561. However, only one play on a Biblical theme, *King Darius*,<sup>43</sup> could have been a touring play. Indeed, of all the plays we have been considering, it is the most blatant touring piece, mentioning Buckingham, Peterborough, and Southampton, as well as Newgate, in the text that has survived. Its structure is much like the ‘money’ plays with two distinct streams — one concerning two episodes in the court of Darius and one depicting the allegorical figures of Charity, Equity, and Constancy in dialogue with Inequity, Importunity, and Partiality. The two apparently separate threads are tied together because the actions of the king with, first, the kings of Ethiopia, Persia, Judah, and Media and then with his courtiers are mirrored in the moral victory of the Virtues over the Vices in the debate. In this way Bevington suggests that ‘the allegory ... relates to story of Darius to contemporary England and the Reformation’.<sup>44</sup>

The virtuous figures in the allegory are clearly Protestant. At one point Equity prays for the Vices:

O lord I hartely thee beseche  
 Thy ryght hand to these synners foorth reache  
 And plucke from theyr malyciousnes  
 Theyr papystry and all theyr coueytousnes  
 Geue to them a good and godly mynde  
 In theyr heades thy commaundements fast binde  
 Conuert them from theyr syn  
 Whych they do wallow in  
 And indue them with all  
 Thy mercye thy grace  
 And let them haue the glasse  
 Of mercye if they call

C iij<sup>r</sup>

Earlier, Equity enunciates the Protestant notions of the benefits of faith:

Good thoughtes by fayth we do obtayne  
 And by fayth we gyt our profyt and gayne  
 Through faith so many as do beleue  
 Prosperous thoughtes god will them geue,  
 As in the booke of wisdome we do rede  
 That the lord loketh vpon faithe & beholdeth it indede. Cj<sup>r</sup>

Bevington discusses *King Darius* in *Mankind to Marlowe* in his chapter 'The Transition to Chronicle' where he also discusses the last play that I want to touch on, Preston's *Cambyses*.<sup>45</sup> Because it is regularly anthologised, this play is probably the most familiar to modern readers. The court of the murderous Cambyses, the precursor of such later favourites as the court of Rasni of Ninevah in *Looking Glass for London*<sup>46</sup> and that of Marlowe's Tamburlaine, is set in a 'mirror' structure, as Bevington describes it, similar to *King Darius* with the scenes of the antics of Ambidexter and the other Vices alternating with the scenes of serial murder by the king. The two strands are tied together by Ambidexter's commentary on the main plot culminating in the lines:

What a king was he that hath vsed such tyranny!  
 He was a kin to Bishop Bonner, I think verely. 203-4

Bonner, bishop of London 1540-1559, became an ardent persecutor of Protestants during the Marian period. Although *Cambyses* does not share the religious themes of the other plays we have been considering, there is no doubt where Preston's religious sympathies lay.

These few plays can only give a sample of the possible repertoire of the early Elizabethan touring companies. Not all plays were printed and, of course, the plays of John Bale suitable for touring were undoubtedly revived. This analysis has also done these plays a disservice in emphasizing their underlying seriousness. They are also full of song, of traditional clowning, of sight gags and of horseplay that would have entertained while at the same time sending a strong Protestant message to audiences throughout the kingdom, emphasizing the seditious nature of Catholicism. Paul White quite rightly makes a strong case for the Robert Dudley as a patron of Protestant drama. My statistics for the first five years of Elizabeth's reign confirms that conclusion, with only nine fewer recorded appearances of his company than the company of the Queen herself. But the Queen's company in this period was not the famous Queen's Men established fifteen years later in 1583, nor, I suggest, was Lord Robert's company yet the Earl of Leicester's Men that rose to such prominence in

the 1570s. These plays could be played by four or five players while the repertoire of the Queen's Men demands at least ten. What this study has done is add a layer of complexity to early Elizabethan dramatic touring. It strongly suggests that during the first ten years of Elizabeth's reign careful control was kept of whose players were on the road, that the companies were small and that the plays they were presenting were rooted in the traditions of religious moralities with the emphasis on debate and dialogue turned to the task of asserting Protestant ascendancy.

But the political climate began to change at the end of the 1560s. The suppression of the rising of the Northern Earls in 1569 was a major triumph for Elizabeth's government. More local touring companies began to appear towards the end of the decade; the tight control of the companies seems to loosen. At the same time, the government, and the church it controlled, began the active suppression of the community religious drama in the north. Matthew Hutton's first move against the Creed Play in York was in 1568; the last performance of the York Cycle in 1569 was held under the shadow of the impending rising of the earls; 1572 saw the end of religious drama in York with the disputed performance of the Pater Noster Play and, the next year, York appointed its first civic preacher. That year also saw the beginning of the struggle between the Puritan clergy in Chester backed by the Ecclesiastical Commission of the North and the Chester city council over the performance of the Chester Plays.<sup>47</sup> The last mention of active municipal religious drama comes from Hutton's letter to the bailiff burgesses of Wakefield in 1576 stopping a performance they were planning of a play depicting members of the Trinity.<sup>48</sup>

The last two plays we looked at, *Cambyeses* and *King Darius*, seem the first harbingers of a new emphasis in English touring plays. Plays based on history sometimes set in the Biblical past or the exotic world being explored by English seamen but also, and increasingly, based on the history of England itself began to replace plays concerned with religion and the bitter struggles of the past. The Elizabethan settlement had been accomplished and, although the religious wars were by no means over, for a period the popular drama turned to plays concerned more with good governance than with correct theology.

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## NOTES

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- 2 Paul Whitfield White *Theatre and Reformation* (Cambridge UP, 1993) 58–9.
- 3 Alexandra F. Johnston ‘William Cecil and the Drama of Persuasion’ in *Shakespeare and Religious Change* edited Kenneth J.E Graham and Philip D. Collington (Basingstoke: Palgrave MacMillan, 2009) 63–87.
- 4 See White *Theatre and Reformation* 14.
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- 6 For a fuller account of this analysis with tables naming the patrons from 1535 see ‘William Cecil and the Drama of Persuasion’.
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19. <<http://www.archive.org/>>; generally available.
20. <[http://lion.chadwyck.co.uk/contents/volumes-uk/Ren\\_dr.jsp](http://lion.chadwyck.co.uk/contents/volumes-uk/Ren_dr.jsp)>; available only through library subscription. See ‘Early English Books Online’ for the originals, also with restricted access through library subscription.
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All URLs are active as of August 2010.